

A pride of lions; and (below) The Ark in Aberdare

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Safari, so good!

The big five—lions, leopards, elephants, Cape buffaloes, and rhinos—are quickly checked off our list, but we also see a whole host of many different species. Zebra, two types of giraffes, varieties of deer, gazelle, hippo, hyena, baboon, ostrich, and unique birds aplenty.

In the Mara, we get to experience lions in many different moods too. Huge ones with massive manes sleeping atop spindly acacia trees that seem like they can barely take the weight. A pride of 10 sleepy ones dozing in the shade, only one or two bothering to wake up to notice us. And then the exciting spectacle of a group of sprightly lionesses planning and executing a high-energy hunt together while the males wait lazily to see what will be served for dinner. The female of this species is certainly deadlier than the male!

Tribal zone

On our way across the Mara, to and from our luxury resort, Keekorok Lodge, we see many Maasai, who seem as hardy as the acacia trees that dot the vast expanses here. Our chauffeur regales us with stories about these hunters and herders, who live in villages that are circular concentrations of huts, and their practice of blood-letting their cattle to survive on a hunt or in times of great drought and famine. The thought of meeting a Maasai warrior in person seems daunting, but their dazzling smiles show how approachable they really are.

The human connection

Our road trip continues, as we travel seven hours across 262 kilometres of a changing landscape from the arid to the lush and refreshing. At the heart of this fertile part of Kenya is the Central Rift Valley. As we gaze across the green bowl of the valley, the thought that this could be the birthplace of all humankind takes our breath away.

For the birds

We arrive at the lakes Naivasha and Nakuru, two of the eight lakes here, which support plenty of birds and animals. Lake Nakuru National Park, which has over 400 bird species



PHOTOGRAPH: PRIYA PATHIYAN